

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Fall Series 4
Painting the Stars ~ An Anticipatory Universe
27 September 2026

COMMUNION

Preaching: LVF

Worship Leading: ML and Sarah Fuhrmeister

Tech needs:

Piano, amplification, monitors for Christoph and choir

Organ Prelude-Concert

Improvisation on HYFRYDOL and HYMN TO JOY

Dance No. 2 for organ (Philip Glass)

Prelude in C Major, BWV 545/1 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

[ML & Sarah to center chancel]

Welcome

ML

Good morning and welcome to FCCLA! We give thanks for your presence here and your presence online, as we welcome all from near and far. We are a community that encourages and celebrates the fullness of who we are, a community where we are free to love whom we love, and where we are equipped to explore faith and spirituality at our own pace.

Today, we continue our fall series, *Painting the Stars*, as Rev. Laura explores *An Anticipatory Universe*. Let us open our whole selves to the Sacred within and all around us as we share these Words of Gathering.

[CB plays creation/2001 Space Odyssey Pedal Notes]

Words of Gathering

ML & SF

SF: In the beginning was a sound, a silence,
a consonant, a vowel,
a mumble, a sigh,
a shout.

ML: In the beginning was an idea,
a possibility, an urge and an urgency,
a compulsion, a wonder,
a love.

SF: In the beginning was the Word,
the Creation, the Articulation,
the Invitation, the Choice,
the Name, the Yes.

ML: This morning as we worship the God of all language and nuance,
we pray that our hearts will break open to the new beginnings
that surround us in this sacred space. [rhackenberg]

SF: *Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering*

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

***Hymn Of Gathering** *Joyful, Joyful, We Adore Thee*

HYMN TO JOY

Joyful, joyful, we adore you, God of glory, God of love;
Hearts unfold like flowers before you, opening to the sun above.
Melt the clouds of sin and sadness, drive the storms of doubt away;
Giver of immortal gladness, fill us with the light of day.

All your works with joy surround you, earth and heaven reflect your rays,
Stars and angels sing around you, center of unbroken praise.
Field and forest, vale and mountain, flowery meadow, flashing sea,
Chanting bird and flowing fountain teach us what our praise should be.

You are giving and forgiving, ever blessing, ever blessed,
Well-spring of the joy of living, ocean depth of happy rest!
Loving Spirit, Father, Mother, all who love belong to you;
Teach us how to love each other, by that love our joy renew.

Mortals, join the mighty chorus, which the morning stars began;
God's own love is reigning o'er us, joining people hand in hand
Ever singing, march we onward, Victors in the midst of strife;
Joyful music leads us sunward In the triumph song of life.

[Michael center chancel]

Prayer of Awareness

ML

God of Creativity,
 whose renewing breath fills our planet,
 may we discover your vibrant, creative presence among us.
 On this day, may our spirits be lifted as we celebrate
 with the clouds, the winds, the dusk, and the dawn.

And then, O God, as we stand in awe
 before the vast reaches of space above us,
 may we give thanks for this fragile piece of stardust
 we call Earth.

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us.

Amen and Amen!

[All turn towards choir]

Introit

Grand Celebration
 Cathedral Ringers, Grace Sheldon-Williams, *Director*

Derek Hayes

[Sarah to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer**

SF

Let us pray together this responsive Lord's Prayer, reimagined by Francis McNab.

Dear One, closer to us than our own hearts, farther from us than the most distant star,
 you are beyond naming. May your powerful presence become obvious not only in the
 undeniable glory of the sky, but also in the seemingly base and common processes of the earth.
 Give us what we need, day by day, to keep body and soul together, because clever as you have
 made us, we still owe our existence to you.

*We recognize that to be reconciled with you, we must live peaceably and justly with other
 human beings, putting hate and bitterness behind us. We are torn between our faith in your
 goodness and our awareness of the evil in your creation, so deliver us from the temptation to
 despair. Yours alone is the universe and all its majesty and beauty.*

Good caring presence within us, around us, and above us; Hold us in a sense of mystery and
 wonder. Let the fullness of your goodness be within us and around us; Let all the world know
 your ways of caring and generosity.

*May we find we have all we need to meet each day without undue anxiety. Overlook our many
 stupidities, and help us to release everyone from their stupidities. May we all know that we are
 accepted.*

Strengthen us so that we will reach out to the best, always with the faith to rise above the ugly realities of our existence. And as we celebrate the gifts you have given us – the rich kingdom of life's possibilities, the power to do good and the triumphs of good, let us be ever thankful for the moments when we have seen the glory and wonder of everything!

***You are life's richness. You are life's power. You are life's ultimate meaning.
Amen and Amen.***

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Michael center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

ML

The peace of the morning's stillness
the peace of new beginnings
the peace of heaven's kiss
to welcome us to this day
to root us in this day
to free us for this day
that we may grow with the greening earth
that we may grow from the ground of glory
that we may grow in grateful wonder of You
Gracious Giver of this day
Great Giver of this day. [jphilipnewell]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

***You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow
Please be seated***

[Sarah to lectern]

Reading from Our Religious Tradition *from Genesis 1*

SF

**Listen now to this reading from Genesis 1 found in a paraphrase by the Celtic Theologian,
J. Philip Newell...**

In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth.
Before that there was only empty darkness and the deep
eternal waters.
But in the dark, a wind began to stir.
It was the breath of life.
It was God saying, 'Let there be light.'

And there was light.
 God saw that it was good.
 There was a time for light and a time for darkness.
 The light was called day and the darkness night.
 And there was evening and morning, creation's first day.

This is the witness of the ancients...

Thanks be to God!

[Christoph transition Michael to center chancel]

Prayers with the People

ML

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

It is in the temple of our inner being,
 in the temple of our bodies,
 in the temple of earth, sea, and sky,
 in the great temple of the universe
 that we look for the light that was in the beginning,
 the mighty fire that blazes still from the heart of life,
 glowing in the whiteness of the moon,
 glistening in the night stars,
 hidden in the sacred black earth,
 concealed in the unknown depths of our souls.

[J. Philip Newell]

Often we fail to remember where to look to find ourselves,
 and each other.

This morning as we come to this time of silence and meditation
 let us remember who we are and with gratitude,
 open ourselves to the great compassion of God
 that is among us, around us, and within us.

Silence

[2 minutes of silence, then Christoph transition out of silence]

Prayer of Our Hearts

Gracious God, how often our names for you
 fail to describe your majesty and mystery.
 When we think we have captured your essence,
 another realm appears,
 reminding us you are beyond
 all language and image.

You speckle the ink-dark night with your star-writing,
you soften the sun-stark day with your cloud brush.

Our minds can barely comprehend –
the ways in which you continue to work
with the single-celled to the infinitely-complex creatures,
as you continually create and re-create.

You speak slyly from inside the bosons
and stride boldly beyond the galaxies.

You cannot, must not, will not be contained
by our meager words and skewed vision,
yet you answer our cries, no matter the name we use.

*Teach us, Eternal One,
to work beyond the bounds of our labels and language.
Help us to leave the comfort of our narrow images.
Remind us that you are All in All,
and that no matter who we are,
or where we reside,
you are with us
in all space and time.
Amen and Amen!*

[JerryHebenstreit/adaptlvf]

[Christoph transition for Laude]

Meditation Anthem

Lux Aurumque

Eric Whitacre

Laude, Katelyn Dietz, *Solo*, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

[Christoph transition Laura to pulpit]

Sermon

An Anticipatory Universe

LVF

[Christoph transition as Michael & Laura go behind communion table]

The Eucharist and Blessings

LVF & ML

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

ML: We who gather at this table come from many places,
differing in age, differing in race,
differing in orientation, politics, and even religion.

LVF: As we come together around this table
we discover that our differences are indeed a blessing,
the more difference we bring, the more fully we experience

the presence of the sacred in our midst.

ML: So come children of God, children of the universe, just as you are.
Wherever you are on this journey of life, you are welcome here,
here in this place, here in this community, here at this table.
Come children of God, children of the universe,
and remember with us.

LVF: We remember the stories that the friends of Jesus told,
stories of bread broken and shared, feeding a multitude,
stories of being gathered together, enemy and friend, around tables,
stories of unlikely guests revealing the face of the sacred.

ML: [Laura breaks bread]

They say that
it was on a night of both celebration and betrayal
that Jesus took the bread leftover on the table,
blessed it and broke it;
reminding them that it is
in the breaking that we become whole,
in losing our lives that we find them,
in serving that we are served.
As the grain scattered becomes one in the loaf,
when we eat this bread, we become one with another.

LVF: [Michael pours cup]

They say that Jesus also took the cup that was leftover
on the table, poured out and sharing,
remembering with them, the life-giving breath
even now pounding a rhythm in our veins,
the breath of life from whence we come
the breath that proceeds and follows all that we can see.
As the grapes find life in the vine,
when we drink this cup,
we become at one with life itself.

Prayer of Blessing

ML: Holy One,
we come to this table,
incarnating in our blood and bones,
in chemistry and consciousness,
this shape-shifting universe.

As we receive this bread and this cup –
symbols of self-giving love,
we remember Jesus and his love that continues
to evolve in each of our lives.

We pray this with the Spirit of Life
that flowed through Jesus
and now flows through our bodies
and into this world.

LVF: You are welcome at this table if you have a little faith, a lot of faith, absolutely no faith, or are of another faith. This is the Table of the Christ, and the welcome is wide!

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

[Sarah to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity

SF

The writer J. Philip Newell believes
our times of religious observation
and meditative practice
are not merely alternatives to encountering God
in the ever-flowing stream of life.
We need both...every day.

When we come to this place each week,
we are given an opportunity to prepare ourselves
to be alert to the One who is always and everywhere present,
closer to us than we are to ourselves.

We do not have to go to the farthest reaches of the universe to find God.
God is here with us – God is everywhere with us.

In gratitude for the light we are given in this life,
we now offer our tithes, our gifts, and ourselves
as our morning offerings are given and received.

You will find information for online giving in your programs and appearing on your screens at home. Our Hospitality Team will also come forward now to receive your offerings. Thank you

for your ongoing generosity through the resources, time, and talents you bring to strengthen our community to be the Love of the Divine in the world.

Offertory

Choose Something Like a Star Randall Thompson
Dr. Christoph Bull, *Piano*, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Sarah to lectern]

***Prayer of Offering**

SF

Eternal God, we pray aware that you,
who are at work
in the vastness of this universe
for billions of years,
will now come to visible
and audible expression
in and through these offerings.

With appreciation in our hearts,
we rejoice, O God,
that you breathe life and vitality
into our world,
into our lives,
and into our gathering here,
connecting us on the deepest level
with all that exists.

*For this and so much more,
we offer our thanks on this day.
Amen and Amen! Please be seated*

[Michael center chancel]

Life at First Church**ML**

-Mention events in program inserts

-Join us next Sunday as our Fall Series, *Painting the Stars*, concludes with the theme, *We are Stories & Stardust*.

-We are no longer accepting clothing donations, or housewares, books, or DVDs. Please find other organizations with whom to share. We will open a specific window in November for our Warm Clothing Drive, but will not take donations before that.

-Join us for Coffee Hour today in Mayflower Courtyard!

Words of Blessing**LVF**

May the Great Mystery that we call God
keep alive in each one of us
the search for a Faith that is real;
a Faith that helps us to lead genuine lives;
a Faith that gives us a fuller
meaning to life and the events of life.

*Bring us to know the goodness that flows
from the heart of the universe,
and may we be expanded in heart and soul
by that goodness.*

*This is our prayer...
May it be so for all of us!*

Choral Response

We are the Ones
We are the ones we've been waiting for

Bernice Johnson Reagon

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]***Hymn for the Journey*****When in Awe of God's Creation*****HYFRYDOL**

When, in awe of God's creation, we view earth from outer space,
This mysterious, floating marble, strewn with clouds and bathed in grace,
How can we not pause in wonder, seeing earth as one and whole?
As we heal our proud divisions, may earth's healing be our goal.

Blue and tan, with lace clouds swirling, flung in space and circling there,
Habitat for myriad creatures meant for land and sea and air!
Must we draw our lines of hatred marking nation, class, and race?
God, forgive us, we entreat you, for all pride of self and place.

Living now, this is the picture we no longer can deny,
 For we see no angry boundaries when our view is from the sky:
 Rivers, deserts, forests, snowfields, oceans, lakes, and mountains too,
 But no fences built for barring you from me or me from you.

[Michael center chancel]

Postlude

Fugue in C Major, BWV 545/2 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Inside The Music - Dr. Ianthe Marini

In today's exploration of the theme *An Anticipatory Universe* we "ring in the new" with Grace leading our Cathedral Ringers. Bells traditionally signifying a call to something new...an anticipation of announcement or time or an invitation to guide our spirits, as they do today in the Derek Hayes *Grand Celebration*.

In meditation, we center the philosophy by 6th century Celtic monk, Pelagius, who taught that human nature at birth is already a reflection of the Divine—that God exists in all creatures, human and non, and that when we look into the face of a newborn baby, we look into the face of God. Whitacre's anthem *Lux Aurumque* sets the short poem by Edward Esch, "*light, warm and heavy as pure gold, and the angels sing softly to the newborn babe.*" While typically sung at Christmas time, today we sing these words in our meditating on the theme of a universe that anticipates—that there in the face of a newborn is God—a hope and anticipation that exists within each of us, and that enlightens our interactions with one another. This gentle and tender, majestic and magical, careful though excited treatment of one another is heard throughout the piece in close harmonies, anticipatory homophonic rhythmic language, and the spectrum of dynamic color.

In the Offertory Anthem, Randall Thompson's setting of the Robert Frost poem *Choose Something like a Star*, Thompson has composed music that is all the way throughout anticipatory in nature. With a bass line that gives consistent heart beat, with scalar passages leading us from one place to the next, with harmonic language that keeps us listening and engaged as it constantly leads us somewhere else, and with a dynamic scope that landscapes and illustrates the range of human emotion, we can hear Frost's poem as he marvels at the Universe. And at the close of our day, we sing Bernice Johnson Reagon's setting of a call from the Civil Rights movement—*We are the ones we've been waiting for*. In the face of a newborn baby reflecting

the Divine, in rung celebration of something new, in the stars whose brightness burns within us, we must be the ones to dream love, change, justice, equity, light into our world.